

3.1 How To Tell

So how do you decide that the battle has begun and that a full system scan is in order?

Whether you love your computer enough to have given it a name or whether it's someone else's property that you just work at, you know your computer best. It's easiest for *you* to tell if your computer is infected. The keywords: "odd behaviour." If you say to yourself, more than five times a day, "Now how did *that* happen?"—you're probably infected. Actually, there's one more question on that list: "Why is this thing so *slow*?"

Having said that, we need to decide on what "slow" and "odd" mean. First off, whatever your machine, you know when it's running slower than usual, and when that happens, there's a possibility that you're infected. Windows pop up more slowly. Random activity seems to be happening in the background more often than it should. Something negative seems to have happened to the overall responsiveness of the system.

One thing to remember is that slow behaviour could also be due to spyware, and it doesn't necessarily mean a virus. Of course, it could be nothing at all, and all in your head.

If you're using a firewall such as Zone Alarm, which tell you what program is trying to "act as a server" or is trying to "access the Internet," note the names of those programs. If you think they shouldn't be asking for access, you might be infected. But remember that lots of programs these days try and update themselves automatically, so there could be several false alarms. Reduce these by turning off automatic updates on all your programs, though that might mean looking through a lot of menus. If some programs are still asking for access, The Bad Thing might just have happened to your computer.

Then there's the System Configuration Utility, activated by typing in "msconfig" at a command prompt. Run it and take a good,